

WORLD WAR II ARMoured VEHICLE

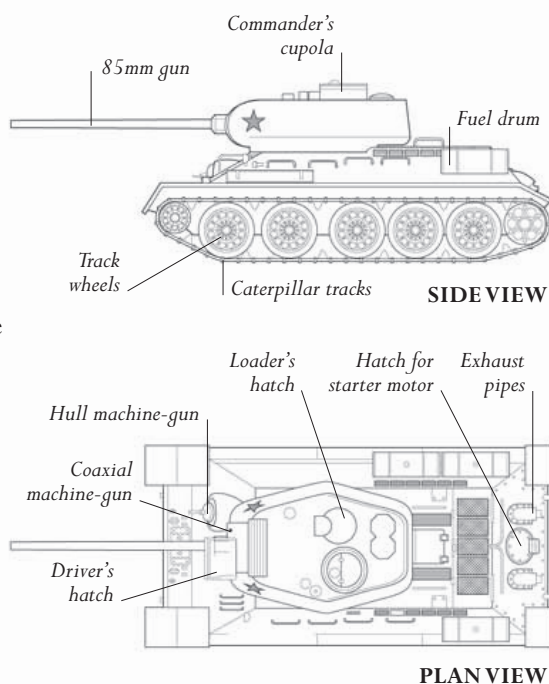
T-34 TANK

Although crudely finished, noisy, and cramped, the Soviet Union's T-34 was perhaps the most successful tank of World War II, taking on and eventually beating the formidable German panzers.

Designated the T-34/76, the tank first saw action in 1941. It mounted a 76.2mm main gun and two 7.62mm DT machine-guns, one in the turret and one in the hull. The coaxial machine-gun in the turret fired tracer rounds to guide the main gun. The T-34 had a four-man crew, with the tank commander doubling as the main gunner.

Thanks to its simple design, the T-34 was easy to mass-produce – nearly 40,000 were built before the war's end – and to repair. Relatively light in weight, it could achieve an impressive 51kph (32mph) and coped well with mud, snow, and broken ground. Its sloped armour, 100mm (4in) thick, gave good protection, while the high-velocity gun penetrated enemy armour effectively.

In 1944, with the T-34 outclassed by more advanced German tanks, the T-34/85 model entered service. Its upgraded 85mm gun gave greater firepower, and the more spacious turret, which had room for three crew, allowed the roles of commander and gunner to be separated.



▲ SOVIET T-34/85

The five-man T-34/85 had a longer main gun than its predecessor. Its flatter turret gave it a lower profile and made it a more difficult target.

TANK EXTERIOR



▲ HULL MACHINE-GUN

The machine-gun muzzle was able to pivot on its mounting. The hole above the muzzle is a gun sight.



▲ TOWING ROPE EYE

A wire hawser (large rope) ran along the side of the tank. It could be used to haul damaged vehicles from the battlefield.

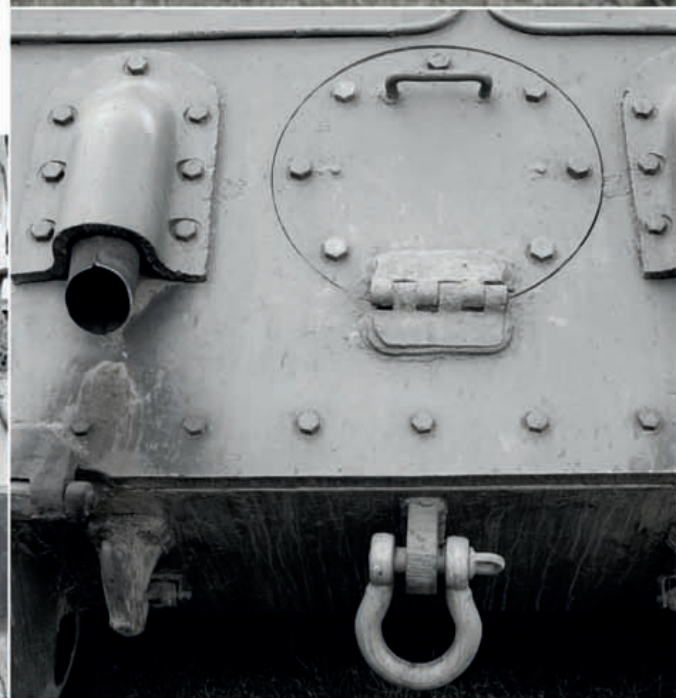
▼ DRIVER'S HATCH

The entrance hatch for the driver was usually left open to give him a better view of the way ahead.



◀ SPARE TRACK ON TURRET

Spare links for repairing the T-34's wide tracks were carried on the outside of the tank.



▲ EXHAUST PIPES AND STARTER MOTOR HATCH

The exhausts tended to billow clouds of smoke when the engine started up. The noisy engine could be heard from 450m (500 yards) away.



▲ FUEL DRUMS

The drums of spare diesel fuel were a fire hazard in battle, so they were usually emptied before combat.

